

The Occurrence of Envy: Annotated Bibliography

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Author Note

This article is based on data published in Kristal et al (2019), Van de Ven (2016), and Kanten et al (2007).

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Cohen-Charash, Y. & Larson, E. C. (2017). An emotion divided: Studying envy is better than studying “benign” and “malicious” envy. *Current Directions in Psychological Science*, 26(2), 174-183. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0963721416683667>

With the study of envy increasing in the social psychology world it has come to the point of often differentiating envy by “benign” or “malicious”. The appeal to using these types is based in how other languages often have different translations, as is the case with many emotions. The problem, however, is that often the characterization of these two types of envy overlooks the broader scope of what envy is. “Malicious” envy is placed in a box where it must connote negative intentions for others. “Benign”, some say, is a different emotion entirely more akin to admiration. Cohen-Charash & Larson (2017) state that envy is neither stating that “Envy includes the motivation to reduce the pain it entails and to improve one’s relative standing.”

The researchers include that studying envy can be tricky, often trying to examine “benign” and “malicious” is impractical for scientific measurement. They included best practices to begin the study of envy. A researcher determined to study envy must first conceptualize envy with feelings, cognitions, and its tendencies. Next, since there are many ways that envy has been studied a methodology must be fully designed. This looks like operationalizing objective criteria, studying reactions, and adding control variables. Finally, do not be hung up on including “benign” and “malicious” when presenting findings. Just study envy to study envy.

Cohen-Charash, Y., & Larson, E. What is the nature of envy? (2016). In R. H. Smith, U.

Merlone, & M. K. Duffy (Eds.), *Envy at work and in organizations* (1st ed., pp. 1-38). <https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780190228057.003.0001>,

Envy has been studied for years and is prominent in psychology, sociology, and philosophy. However, a clear definition of envy has been hard to find. Different languages have been brought in to define envy using terms such as “benign” and “malicious” as well as attempting to determine the strength of the envy. These additional terms have created much conceptual ambiguity for envy. Cohen-Charash and Larson (2016) contend with the additional terminology and implore researchers to study envy as it is, a complex emotion that cannot simply be classified as good or bad. The psychological perspective on envy is closely linked to social comparison theory, where individuals evaluate themselves based on how they perceive others. Envy tends to occur when someone sees themselves as lacking in comparison to someone else who has a desirable trait, possession, or success. This upward comparison triggers envy, especially if the envious person believes they are like the envied individual but less fortunate.

Envy has been historically defined as dangerous, destructive, and negative. Biblically it is mainly defined as sinful, linked to murder and the loss of family birthrights. Within organizations the authors have described two envies; destructive workplace envy which can lead to gossip and even sabotage and constructive workplace envy which can motivate employees to work harder and improve. Envy is usually unpleasant, but it doesn't always yield negative outcomes. The researchers have concluded by inviting others to study more the outcomes of these destructive and

constructive types of envy. Behaviors of envy vary depending on the person. If we can improve the likelihood of constructive envy, we can improve our societies.

Kanten, A. B., & Teigen, K. H. (2007). Better than average and better with time: Relative evaluations of self and others in the past, present, and future. *European Journal of Social Psychology*, 38(2), 343-353. <https://doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.457>

To test a well thought of but rarely researched phenomena on perceptions of self and others in past, present, and future tenses, Kanten & Teigen (2007) sought to be pioneers in this study of through the lens of temporal distance. The 385 participants in the research study, randomly assigned to one of six test conditions, were students from the University of Oslo. In each questionnaire participants evaluated themselves in comparison to other same aged and gendered peers. The first four groups were asked to consider 10 desirable and 10 undesirable traits for themselves and for their peers in different tenses. The remaining two groups depicted only themselves in the past and future based on the 20 characteristics.

The researchers found significant evidence that those who compare themselves to others generally rate themselves higher in desirable attributes and others as higher in undesirable attributes. In comparing one's present self to their past self they rated themselves as more undesirable in the past than the present. In comparing oneself to the future, the desirable attributes were rated as much higher.

Since we can view our past faults and failures and current improvements it is easy to compare ourselves as better than before. We want to believe that we have been on a continual increase, that we are consistently changing for the better and we can expect more of that from ourselves in the near future. Often when we consider others, we more

easily categorize them based on the minimal observations we make. It is more difficult to see others as part of a whole person with individual desires and improvements. It is important to think outside of our own brains, to continue to expect improvement but to expect that from others.

Klein, N., & O'Brien, E. (2018). People use less information than they think to make up their minds. *Psychological and Cognitive Sciences*, 115(52), 13222-13227.

<https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1805327115>

Klein and O'Brien (2018) conducted seven studies with over 2,000 participants to study people's formation of opinions. Classifying by "experiencers" who decided when they had gathered enough information to form an opinion, and "predictors", after sampling the stimulus, estimated how much information they needed to do the same. Across the seven studies the researchers explored decision-making processes, with participants reporting or predicting how quickly an opinion is formed across different scenarios such as art preferences, taste testing, relationships, and candidate evaluation. They found that predictors overestimate how much evidence is required to decide, while experiencers quickly make decisions, leading to a gap between expectation and reality.

Even with information readily available, often, while forming opinions we assume that more information gathering is required but in practice we don't act like it. There are real-world implications to not "doing the research". If we consider this for situations where more information could lead to better decisions, such as in legal judgments, financial investments, or policymaking it's a big deal. It's important for us to be aware of how quickly we make selections based on media enticements, advertisements, and trusted opinions. Gathering facts is a human right that perhaps we don't utilize enough,

especially when it matters most. Discernment comes easier when we have viewed a situation from all angles.

Kristal, A. C., O'Brien, E., & Caruso, E. M. (2019). Yesterday's news: A temporal discontinuity in the sting of inferiority. *Psychological Science*, 30(5), 643-656.

<https://doi.org/10.1177/0956797619839689>

Kristal et al. (2019) conducted four studies examining envy under the scope of time. Hypothesizing that envy is more prevalent before an expected event, they studied its effects across different scenarios and time. Sample groups of 100 or more were created from students, adults from downtown Chicago, and employees at Amazon's Mechanical Turk. The occurrence of envy towards friends was measured in past, present, and future tenses. Participants were requested to imagine a close friend achieving their dream vacation, date, job, house, and new car. These scenarios were imagined as an upcoming event and as a goal already achieved.

Envy was measured on February 13th, 14th, and 15th. As predicted, knowing someone had a date for Valentine's Day before February 14th was more enviable than knowing it after the holiday. The peak of envy was reached on February 14th and dropped significantly on the 15th. Kristal et al. (2019) realized that the anticipated event was much more likely to bring on envy from peers than when that event is realized. The researchers also examined malicious and benign envy in future and past tenses. Finding that malicious envy is more prevalent when considering future events and benign more so for past events cause the researchers to study regulation of negative emotion. They tested if tense can be fabricated as a form of emotional regulation. Kristal et al. (2019) found that envy, viewed through a past perspective was the most effective in reducing envy.

Loewenstein, G. (1987). Anticipation and the valuation of delayed consumption. *The Economic Journal*, 97(387), 666–684. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2232929>

Loewenstein (1987) challenged the common belief that people will always choose immediate rewards and delayed costs. He used the terms savoring, which is enjoyment in anticipation of future pleasure, and dread, which is the discomfort in the anticipation of future pleasures. The key word is anticipation. Using these terms the researcher studied savoring and dread in scenarios such as financial and relationship factors. 30 college students were asked to imagine a scenario either positive or negative and say how much they would pay to receive or avoid each outcome presented to them at different times. The times were immediately, after one day, 3 days, 1 year, and after 10 years.

Loewenstein (1987) found that participants were willing to pay more to delay pleasurable experiences, savoring the pleasure. They would also rather pay to minimize dread, accelerating the more undesirable situations to now. These results were more limited to the circumstances of pain and romance but when it came to money-related outcomes the roles were more reversed. As predicted, the participants preferred to have an increase of money early and delay the loss of monetary gain. The results demonstrate that anticipation is a powerful motivator for pleasure as the anticipation of a pleasurable experience makes it all the sweeter.

O'Brien, E. (2015). Mapping out past and future minds: The perceived trajectory of rationality versus emotionality over time. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*, 144(3), 624–638. <https://doi.org/10.1037/xge0000064>

O'Brien is fascinated with the temporal sphere, particularly how one perceives themselves in the past and in the future. To study the effects of emotionality and

rationality within the past and future. The six studies performed each gave significant evidence that we view ourselves as more emotional in the past and less emotional in the future. For rationality, the participants viewed their past selves as less rational and the future selves as more rational. As these studies were all self-assessment based, participants imagined a conversation-like scenario with their current, past, and future selves. Participants connecting with their future selves described improved self-control, while those connecting with their past selves engaged more in activities intended for enjoyment. In all, O'Brien relates that the manner which we view ourselves is dependent on the direction we're facing. If we view ourselves as emotional, maybe we're looking back. If we view ourselves as rational, maybe we're looking forward. We can determine the path we take based on who we face to.

Przybylski, A. K., Murayama, K., DeHaan, C. R., & Gladwell, V. (2013). Motivational, emotional, and behavioral correlates of fear of missing out. *Computers in Human Behavior*, 29(4), 1841-1848. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2013.02.014>

“FOMO” often known as the fear of missing out is described by the researchers as “a pervasive apprehension that others might be having rewarding experiences from which one is absent” (Przybylski et al, 2013). The researchers performed three research studies to begin comprehending this “FOMO” phenomenon particularly within the context of social media. In study one, 32 depictions of events that would illicit feelings of missing out were presented to 1013 international participants recruited using Amazon's Mechanical Turk system. Each participant was asked to relate each depiction to themselves and their level of missing out. The second study sought to identify FOMO in individuals whose basic needs were satisfied daily as well as an evaluation of their well-

being in association with social media was examined. The third study sought to examine how behaviors in real life are affected by social media demonstrating that young adults are missing out. The researchers wanted to test the prevalence of social media use in dividing the attention of today's young adults.

The perceived or anticipated emotion of missing out on a fun event or having others receive the reward of fun and that being presented so often on social media can be detrimental. Young adults especially are succumbing to more focused attention on the upcoming and making sure they are not the ones left behind. Social media, with all its glories, has added to the often-painful experience of not living up to peers in exciting ways. This can lead to feelings of not only missing out but of jealousy and even envy. If we can minimize our use of social media and detach our emotions from what we see, we can learn to be more present and mindful. We should not let these negative emotions drive our life satisfaction because we are comparing ourselves to what is often a skewed version of reality.

Smallwood, J., & Nind, L., & O'Connor, R. C. (2009). When is your head at? An exploration of the factors associated with the temporal focus of the wandering mind. *Consciousness and Cognition Bulletin*, 18(1), 118-125. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.concog.2008.11.004>

Mental time travel is often the term associated with the cognitive process of mind wandering where one's attention is divided to the past or the future. Smallwood, Nind, and O'Connor sought to understand what influences the direction of the wandering mind and how it decides to consider the past or the future. In their first experiment they put different cognitive loads on their participants to observe reaction time, working memory, and a passive viewing task. Participants were to report where in time their thoughts were

focused at the conclusion of each cognitive task. The second experiment tested topic interest and familiarity on mind-wandering. Participants were given a variety of science articles to read and reported on their interest and their temporal focus.

For the cognitive tasks, participants were more inclined to focus on future events also known as prospective thinking when their tasks were less mentally demanding. When their tasks were a higher cognitive load such as the working memory task their future focus was significantly lower. As expected for the second experiment the higher-interested participants showed less mind-wandering and increased present focus. These experiments combined show the quite interesting evidence for cognitive functioning. When we are more interested in the task as well as having to work on and through the mental load of it we are more presently engaged. If the task is dull and the novelty low our minds are more likely to wander.

Smith, R. H., & Kim, S. H. (2007). Comprehending envy. *Psychological Bulletin*, 133(1), 46–64. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.133.1.46>

Envy is the unpleasant emotion that arises when we compare ourselves, particularly our achievements to that of others. Smith and Kim define envy in its two forms, proper and benign. Proper envy is described as connoting feelings of inferiority, hostility, and resentment particularly toward one of similar standing receiving the greater reward. This envy can even present in feelings of pleasure at the downfall of the envied one. This feeling is called “scadenfreude”. Benign harbors no ill feelings of hostility and or destructive but rather can lead to admiration and even emulation. In discussing envy, the authors are careful to distinguish from jealousy, as envy is often associated with other such negative emotions.

Because of its stigmatized nature within societies, many are unwilling to admit envy's presence in themselves. This causes the study of envy to be placed alongside studying other negative emotions and their responses. There are also many When approaching the study of envy, either proper or benign, the authors encourage future researchers to be aware of the behavioral impact of envy, its social context, and strive to create processes of coping with envy. Envy can have personal and social implications. The field of envy can be largely studied, the authors give examples of personal unhappiness, physical health, and prejudice. If we can diminish the stigmatism of envy and increase the coping mechanisms to overcoming the negative impacts of proper envy, we can improve society as a whole, one individual at a time.

Van de Ven, N. (2016). Envy and its consequences: Why it is useful to distinguish between benign and malicious envy. *Social and Personality Psychology Compass*, 10(6), 337-349. <https://doi.org/10.1111/spc3.12253>

It is often said that comparison is the thief of joy, and envy falls under making social comparisons. These comparisons are hard to shake, but we can use the observation of others' successes to either become frustrated and try to sabotage them or become motivated to improve. These two types of envy can be categorized as benign or malicious. Van de Ven (2016), curious about the two types derived from his native Dutch language *afgunst* (malicious envy) and *benijden* (benign envy), asked his fellow dutchmen about these two Dutch definitions. It became clear the emotions associated with each subtype of envy. Malicious envy tends to be negative, even causing pain to the owner of the envy. Malicious envy can be harmful beyond the individual as they harbor

ill will to the successful one. Benign, on the other hand, is considered a much more positive emotion, fueling the intrinsic motivation of success.

Van de Ven (2016) mentioned the type of statements the individual with benign vs malicious envy would be inclined to select. The one with benign will say that they want to meet the accomplishment of the successful one. The one with malicious will say that they would rather the successful one not have the accomplishment. The importance of understanding the two types of envy as we study this often-negative emotion can help us understand its effects on the individual's self-enhancement.